
This Year's Other Oscar Front-Runner Is Here. I Have Tragic News.

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The curiosity that drove the Irish novelist Maggie O'Farrell to write her bestselling 2020 novel *Hamnet* sprang from the scarcity of documentation about the book's title character, Hamnet Shakespeare. Born in 1585 to William and Anne Shakespeare, the twin brother to a girl named Judith, Hamnet died of unknown causes in 1596, the only one of the Shakespeares' three children not to reach adulthood. But for the records of his christening and his burial in the Stratford-upon-Avon parish registers, Hamnet's 11 years on earth remain a tantalizing blank, one of those countless human existences that are legible to us now only in the form of a bookended pair of dates.

And yet, because Hamnet happened to have a father who spent his life creating characters that four centuries on remain as legible and as vibrant as any have ever been, the six letters of this boy's name are all that are needed to suggest an infinity of questions. What was the connection between the loss of the dramatist's only son and the creation, about four years later, of his longest, most linguistically innovative, and—as generations of speculation about its ambiguities attest—philosophically richest play? An epigraph to O'Farrell's novel by the Shakespearean scholar Stephen Greenblatt notes that, given the Elizabethan era's disregard for consistent name spellings, “Hamlet” and “Hamnet” were functionally the same name. Was *Hamlet*, a play entirely caught up with exploring the lived experience of grief, intended in some way as a tribute to the playwright's lost child? And whether or not that was the author's conscious intent, what might it have meant to Anne Shakespeare to learn that her husband, far off in London, was having one of his greatest successes yet with a tragedy that shared a name with the son they had just lost?

O'Farrell's radical gambit is to decenter the character of Shakespeare, placing the book's omniscient third-person narration mainly in the consciousness of his wife Anne (here named Agnes, the name given to the real-life Anne Hathaway Shakespeare in some historical records). The man who is Agnes' husband and the father of her children, though he appears throughout the book as a secondary character, is never given a name. By building her fictional world in the interstices of history, O'Farrell creates space to tell Agnes' story, a domestic tale of maternal grief with touches of magical realism that seem perfectly in keeping with the folk culture of the Shakespeares' time and place.

That Chloé Zhao was the director chosen to helm the adaptation of *Hamnet* would seem to flow directly from the filmmaker's long-standing fascination with natural landscapes and poetic outsider protagonists. Indeed, in a scene in Zhao's Oscar-winning 2020 road movie [Nomadland](#), we hear Frances McDormand, as the movie's van-dwelling heroine, reciting by heart the complete text of Shakespeare's [Sonnet 18](#). Zhao's 2021 Marvel franchise entry *Eternals* was broadly mocked (including by [this critic](#)) for its somberly mystical dialogue and groundbreaking yet turgid scenes of inter-superhero sex. But thematically *Eternals* was of a piece with Zhao's other films, including her still-remarkable directorial debut *Songs My Brothers Taught Me*, in its valorization of its characters' inner experience. De-emphasizing action in favor of an effort to communicate the invisible may make for pretentious tedium in a Marvel blockbuster, but it would seem an ideal approach to adapting a novel like *Hamnet*, whose dramatic action takes place almost entirely within its characters' minds.

Especially for the first third or so of its two-hour-five-minute run time, Zhao's *Hamnet*, co-scripted by the director and O'Farrell herself, seems to be taking place in a landscape that's both inner and outer. The woodland spot where we initially discover Agnes (Jessie Buckley) curled in the fetal

position under a tree will take on multiple symbolic meanings over the course of the movie. A seemingly bottomless hole at the base of the trunk comes to stand in for birth, death, the vortex of grief, and the mystery of art-making. It's a less-than-subtle visual metaphor, but a powerful one nonetheless. When the quietly attentive camera of cinematographer Łukasz Żal ([Ida](#), [The Zone of Interest](#)) lingers among the ferns and leaf litter, with occasional Terrence Malick-style upward gazes into the tree canopy, viewers enter into a contemplative state that seems to align us with the nature-loving Agnes, who, unlike the man who will soon become her husband, has never been one for words.

Agnes is a stubbornly independent spirit, an amateur falconer whose late mother schooled her in the curative properties of native plants. Her propensity for disappearing into the woods and for dispensing homemade herbal remedies has made Agnes the subject of town gossip as a "forest witch." But to the young man hired to teach Latin to Agnes' stepbrothers, who goes unnamed for most of the film but whom, for the sake of clarity, we'll call Will (Paul Mescal), Agnes' enchantments are more earthly. Spotting her out the classroom window with her hawk, he is smitten by her good looks and air of self-possession. Soon they are flirting under Agnes' favorite tree and, not long after, making sweet Shakespearean love in a shed full of newly harvested apples.

When Agnes becomes pregnant, she and her new beau are delighted, but her stepmother kicks her out of the house, and Will's mother, Mary (Emily Watson), is also not thrilled about her eldest son marrying a woman she regards as the town kook. But John Shakespeare (David Wilmot)—an abusive father with a drinking problem who resents his brainy, daydreaming son—grudgingly accepts Agnes into his household. Within two years, Will and Agnes are parents to Susanna (Bodhi Rae Breathnach) and twins Hamnet (Jacobi Jupe) and Judith (Olivia Lynes).

Hamnet the movie seldom if ever reaches the heights of its source material—a big ask, given how difficult it is to adapt any novel as driven by its narrative voice as O'Farrell's. But Zhao captures the book's lyrical naturalism and attention to sensory detail in scenes involving the couple's courtship and time spent playing with their young children. (Jupe, only 11 at the time of filming, deserves all the awards for a stupendously moving and intuitive performance as Hamnet.) These joyful encounters effectively establish the key fact that Will and Anne share a deep bond that's more than sexual—they're soulmates of a sort, even if she doesn't share in his London theater world or particularly care to understand it. Whether Anne Hathaway was able to read or write is not known; in the movie, Agnes is able to scratch out a rudimentary note but hands her elder daughter Will's letters home to read aloud.

Jessie Buckley is the ideal and perhaps only imaginable actor to play the plainspoken, emotionally direct Agnes, who here as in the book has an empathic gift that allows her, under the right conditions, to sense other people's inner states. But Paul Mescal, excellent though he is, strikes me as wrong for the restless, avoidant Will. In the book, Agnes' husband, while ultimately a sympathetic character, comes off early in their marriage as something of a volatile mess, and later, as he begins to achieve career success, displays a faintly off-putting degree of professional ambition. These rough edges are largely sanded off in Zhao and O'Farrell's adaptation, and there's something about this actor's heart-on-his-sleeve expressiveness and buff-teddy-bear physique (Mescaline attributes that I prize in other roles) that make him a more emo, less edgy Bard. I can picture Mescal better in the role (much larger in the book) of Agnes' soft-spoken but staunchly loyal younger brother Bartholomew, here played by Joe Alwyn. As for what actor now working could put across this vision of a young Shakespeare on the rise, I might look to someone with a more mercurial, even mischievous energy: Harris Dickinson? Josh O'Connor?

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The irredeemably cuddly Mescal might not have been my choice to embody the Swan of Avon, but it's the script's treatment of the Shakespeare character, not the actor's interpretation of him, that makes the delicate web Zhao weaves in *Hamnet's* first act start to fray. In scenes when the obscure son of a glover begins to turn into the figure we know he will become, Zhao and O'Farrell's dialogue loses the quality of allusiveness and restraint that characterized it before. Seated at a writing table in his cramped family house in Stratford—years before he sets out for the city, and a decade or more before he will emerge as a rising actor and playwright—this version of the Bard is already scribbling lines that will one day be inserted verbatim into his plays: “But soft! What light through yonder window breaks? / It is the East, and Juliet is the sun,” he murmurs over his inkstand. In an earlier scene, as Will tries to charm Agnes by telling her the story of Orpheus and Eurydice, he concludes with the line “The rest is silence.” It's as if he's doing a test run of Hamlet's future last words before having even conceived the son whose loss was, according to the film's own premise, the inspiration for the play.

These constant reminders that Anne's husband was the man responsible for introducing these phrases into the English language have the effect of recentring Shakespeare in a story whose whole point was to keep him at the margins, as if the filmmakers didn't trust the audience to remember that the hunk in the doublet is indeed the world's greatest playwright in the making. There's even a nails-on-the-blackboard moment toward the end of the movie when the author is finally referred to by his full name, offering any viewer who might still have been confused as to his identity the chance to nudge their date and whisper, “That's William Shakespeare.”

Late in the film, after the wrenching central section involving Hamnet's illness and death of bubonic plague, comes the most grievously misjudged scene involving Will's proclivity for self-quoting. Standing on a ledge high above the Thames, so consumed with grief as to be considering suicide, he delivers the “To be or not to be” soliloquy before deciding, with a turn away from the water's edge, to go on, well, being. The painfully on-the-nose suggestion seems to be that the composition of this speech sprang directly from a personal experience of near self-slaughter, rather than from a rigorous process of writing, performing, and rewriting (something that's particularly well attested

in [the many extant versions](#) of *Hamlet*). But it's less the implausibility that makes this scene so excruciating than the maudlin and literalist context in which this world-famous speech is delivered. As the movie's ending approaches, the cornball biopic energy that the earlier Stratford scenes mostly steered clear of (and that O'Farrell's book entirely eschews) starts to seep through the screen like the rainwaters that flood the Shakespeare family home during an earlier scene.

The movie concludes on a performance of *Hamlet* at the Globe Theatre that's attended by the bereaved Agnes, who has traveled to London in secret to see her husband's work onstage for the first time. In the novel, this makes for one of the best endings I've read in years, the kind of final page that makes you close the book with a hushed "damn." And though the movie retains the basic shape of that ending, Zhao gilds the lily (an expression that comes to us, incidentally, via Shakespeare) by layering on too many elements intended to wring tears from the audience, beginning with composer Max Richter's use of his already overfamiliar string composition "[On the Nature of Daylight](#)"—a piece of music that has appeared on the soundtracks of movies and TV shows from *Arrival* and *Shutter Island* to *The Handmaid's Tale* and *The Last of Us*, and that now can't help but evoke the formless sentimentality of an old long-distance commercial. More damningly, this closing scene takes a small but key gesture Agnes makes in the book and extends it to the Globe audience as a whole, thereby stripping the moment of its intimate, personal meaning. I can't go into more detail without spoiling, but you don't have to be a stickler for the facts to note that there was no need for Zhao to make alterations to the last scene of Shakespeare's *Hamlet* to get across her own dramatic point. The playwright had endings figured out pretty well himself.

Most of my fellow critics, including many whose taste I generally share, seem to have found watching *Hamnet* a transcendent experience, and as a near-evangelical fan of the novel, I both honor and envy their response to the movie. I certainly don't place myself alongside the much smaller school of reviewers who found the whole film mortifyingly overacted. To me, it is a sensitive adaptation full of beautifully judged performances that nonetheless fails to maintain the essential appeal of its own source material: the quietly feminist retelling of one of the most retold lives in history from the perspective of a woman who was central to that life, while figuring almost nowhere in the record of it. If, like me, you come away from the movie remembering Buckley's embodiment of Agnes as the highlight, I might point out that she's also the narrator of the [audiobook](#).

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